

Share An Impediment Newsletter Throughout The Organization

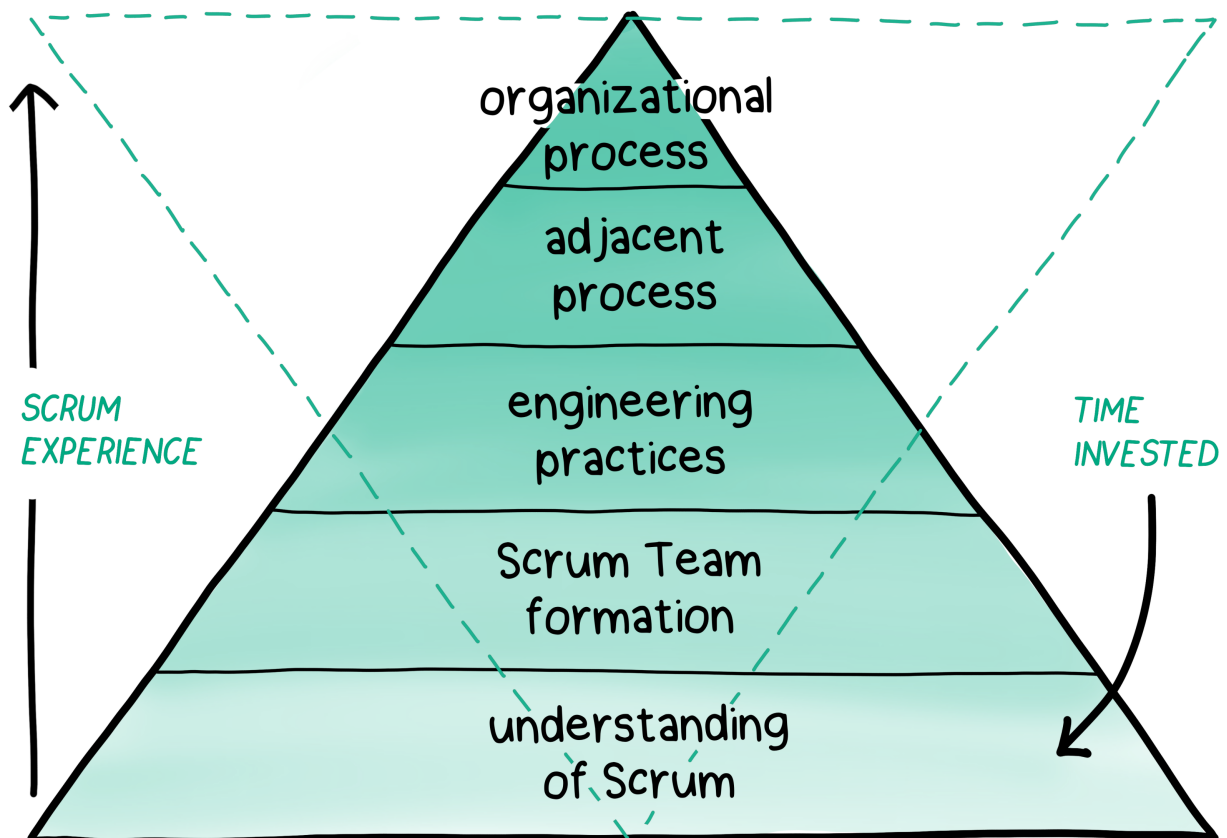
A simple experiment to help people outside your team understand the impediments and the problems they cause



Share an Impediment Newsletter Throughout the Organization

The impediments that make it hard for Scrum Teams to work empirically often involve people across the organization. When you help them understand the impediments, and the problems they cause, you create awareness about what can be improved. This, in turn, opens the door to double-loop learning and to systemic improvements.

We designed this simple experiment to help you create awareness about the problems that your team is running into. After all, if nobody else knows, nothing will ever change.



AS SCRUM TEAMS BECOME MORE EXPERIENCED
WITH SCRUM, THE PYRAMID FLIPS

model by dominik maximini



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



This experiment calls for nothing but courage and a dash of tact.

Impact On Survival



Although painful, this is a great way to create urgency around the biggest problems.



Steps

To try this experiment, do the following:

1. With your Scrum Team, ask everyone to silently write down impediments they see that are making it hard for them to build what stakeholders need and/or ship fast(er). What skills are missing? Where is protocol getting in the way? Which people do they need, but don't have access to? After a few minutes, invite people to pair up to share and build on their individual ideas. Together, share all impediments and pick the three to five impediments that are most impactful (e.g. with dot-voting).
2. For the biggest impediments, ask "What is lost because of this? What do we and our stakeholders gain when this impediment would be removed?". Capture the consequences for the various impediments.
3. For the biggest impediments, ask "Where do we need help? What would help look like?". Collect the requests for help for the various impediments.
4. Compile the biggest impediments, including their consequences and requests for help, in a format that you can easily distribute to everyone who has a stake in your work. It could be a mailing, a paper newsletter, a blog post on your intranet, or a poster that you put in a heavy-traffic corridor. Include the purpose of your team and how to contact you. You can also include the accomplishments of your team, of course.

Our Findings

- Make sure to include (higher) management and consider informing them upfront. Also, they will probably appreciate a shorter, more concise version.
- Transparency can be painful. Be honest but tactful in your messaging, and don't blame others or be negative. State what is happening and make clear requests for help.
- If you are planning to do this frequently, make sure to include the accomplishments of your team as well. What is going well? What has changed since the previous newsletter? And most importantly; from whom did you receive (unexpected) help?

More Resources

Helpful resources

- White paper [The 8 Stances of a Scrum Master](#) with the stance of an Impediment Remover in specific
- Blog post: [Navigating Conflict, a Lifetime of Work](#)
- Blog post: [Conflict Styles: What Sciences Says](#)
- Book: [The Scrum Culture](#). The original book behind the Impediment Pyramid.
- Research: [How Do Scrum Masters Deal With Problems Outside Of Their Team's Control?](#). Together with [Age of Product](#), we asked Scrum Masters how they overcame impediments (including dependencies).

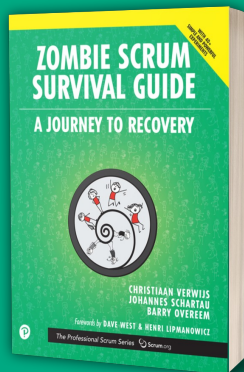
Help Us With Your Feedback



We are eager to learn how this experiment benefitted your team. What did it make possible? How did it help you make progress in your recovery from Zombie Scrum? With your data, we can improve our recommendations to other teams. You can share [your feedback](#) here with us in a only few minutes.



The Zombie Scrum Survival Guide



Zombie Scrum is on the rise! What may look like Scrum from a distance often turns out to be anything but when you take a closer look. Although teams go through the motions of Scrum, Sprints don't result in valuable outcomes, customers are not involved, teams have little autonomy and nobody is doing anything to improve.

A detailed examination of Zombie Scrum

In our book, we share our research and experience in the field with Zombie Scrum. We explore symptoms and causes, and dig deep into why Zombie Scrum usually starts when the purpose of Scrum isn't clear. With our book, the purpose of Scrum was never this clear!

Start your recovery tomorrow

The good news is that recovery is entirely possible. Our book contains over 40 practical experiments to start recovery, even when your organization has succumbed to it completely.

Get your copy now

You can find the 'Zombie Scrum Survival Guide' in your favorite bookstore starting from November 23, 2020. Or buy your copy from us at zombiescrum.org. The book comes with a free digital first aid kit, and a nice discount for a physical kit.



The Zombie Scrum Resistance

The 'Zombie Scrum Survival Guide' is written by Christiaan Verwijns, Johannes Schartau and Barry Overeem, and richly illustrated by Thea Schukken.

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